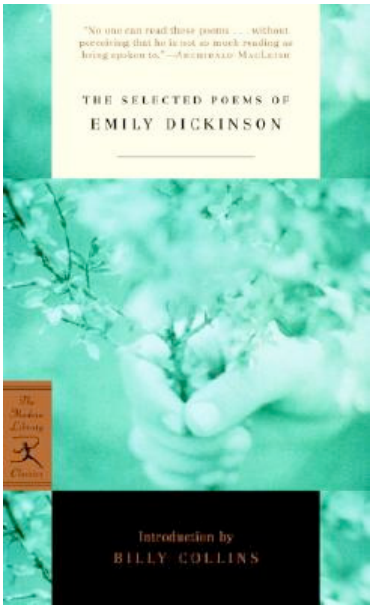
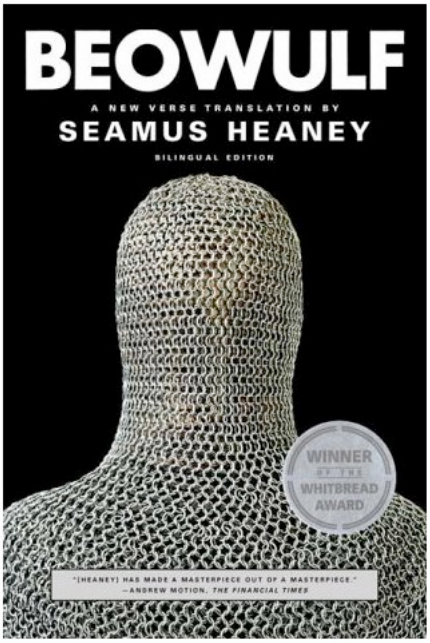
UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

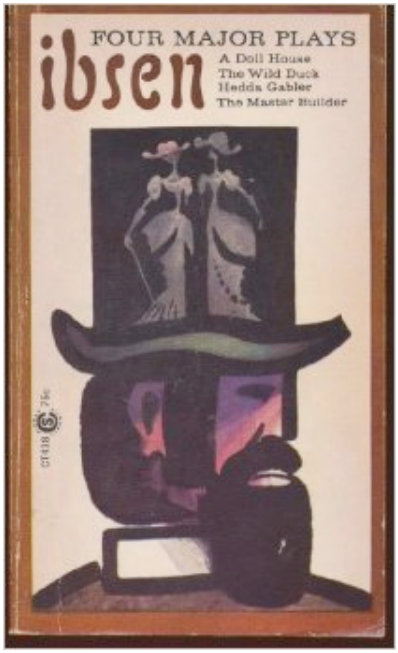
Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

State • 2015







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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • State • 2015

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. A character in the alphabet developed about the second or third century by the Germanic tribes in Europe and carved on stones, drinking horns, and weapons as formulae with magical powers is the

   A) keen.
   B) koine.
   C) logo.
   D) rune.
   E) siglum.

2. The character of the speaker or writer as reflected in speech or writing is known as

   A) bathos.
   B) ethos.
   C) logos.
   D) mythos.
   E) pathos.

3. The Southern writer who has a sixty-year-old manuscript that is being billed as a sequel to her 1961 Pulitzer Prize-winning novel hitting the bookshelves this coming July is

   A) Willa Cather.
   B) Shirley Ann Grau.
   C) Harper Lee.
   D) Carson McCullers.
   E) Eudora Welty.

4. The mode of informal public performance and competition engaged in by poets beginning around 1990 in Chicago is (the)

   A) calypso.
   B) rap.
   C) reggae.
   D) scat.
   E) slam.

5. The study or philosophy of beauty in nature and art, which in literature concentrates on the sense and the experiencing of the beautiful rather than on moral, social, or practical considerations, is

   A) aesthetics.
   B) essentialism.
   C) expressionism.
   D) formalism.
   E) metaphysics.

6. The eighteenth-century Irish author of *A Tale of a Tub, The Battle of the Books, Gulliver's Travels*, "An Argument against Abolishing Christianity," and "A Modest Proposal" is

   A) Samuel Beckett.
   B) Oliver Goldsmith.
   C) John Millington Synge.
   D) Jonathan Swift.
   E) William Butler Yeats.

7. **Not** a literary form that either praises or celebrates a person, an object, or an occasion is the

   A) dirge.
   B) encomium.
   C) epithalamium.
   D) eulogy.
   E) ode.

8. The character or actor, often taking the third rank of importance in a narrative or drama, that the tragedian Sophocles added to Greek drama during the fifth century is the

   A) antagonist.
   B) deuteragonist.
   C) eiron.
   D) protagonist.
   E) tritagonist.

9. The prose genre that involves crime, detection, punishment, and corruption in high places, a genre that includes the thriller, is the

   A) Gothic novel.
   B) novel of incident.
   C) *roman* à *clef*.
   D) *roman noir*.
   E) underground press.

10. The term usually applied to a group of early-twentieth-century Southern American writers in Nashville, Tennessee, who published the little magazine entitled *The Fugitive* is

    A) Agrarians.
    B) Beat Generation.
    C) Knickerbocker Group.
    D) Muckrakers.
    E) Transcendental Club.

11. Another name for the Metaphysical Poets of England's seventeenth century is the

A) Fleshly School of Poetry.
B) Graveyard School.
C) School of Donne.
D) School of Night.
E) School of Spenser.

12. The entreaty addressed to the Muse at the beginning of an epic (the narrative that follows serving in response to that request) is called an

A) epic catalog.
B) epic formula.
C) epic ideal.
D) epic question.
E) epic simile.

13. The term meaning metrically complete that is applied, especially, to a line of poetry having the full number of syllables in the final foot, thus carrying out the basic metrical and rhythmic pattern of a poem, is

A) acatalectic.
B) catalectic.
C) chiasmic.
D) hypercatalectic.
E) vatic.

14. The scientific study of both language and literature, especially in the general use of the term, is called

A) belles-lettres.
B) exegesis.
C) lexicography.
D) philology.
E) synopsis.

15. The species of novel that reconstructs a past age during which, as Walter Scott, who created the category, defines it, two cultures are in conflict and in which fictitious characters move through a recreated world of actual events is the

A) historical novel.
B) *Künstlerroman*.
C) novel of incident.
D) *roman à clef*.
E) *roman de gest*.

16. Originally, a retort or sarcastic jest and now, by extension, any witty saying, is known as (a)

A) antiphrasis.
B) equivoque.
C) litotes.
D) paragram.
E) quip.

17. The analysis, study, and evaluation of individual works of art as well as the formulation of general principles for the examination of such works is

A) criticism.
B) excursus.
C) exegesis.
D) hermeneutics.
E) typology.

18. The nineteenth-century English novels *Jane Eyre*, *Wuthering Heights*, *Agnes Grey*, *The Tenant of Wildfell Hall*, *Villette*, *Shirley*, and *The Professor* were each written by one of the three acclaimed

A) Bennett sisters.
B) Blackwood sisters.
C) Brontë sisters.
D) Dashwood sisters.
E) March sisters.

19. **Not** among names associated with Scottish literature, fiction and nonfiction, is

A) Robert Burns.
B) Geoffrey Chaucer.
C) David Hume.
D) Walter Scott.
E) Adam Smith.

20. The form of light verse that follows a definite pattern: five anapestic lines of which the first, second, and fifth, consisting of three feet, rhyme; and the third and fourth lines, consisting of two feet, rhyme, is the

A) dizain.
B) haiku.
C) limerick.
D) sonnet.
E) virelay.

21. The nickname given to the young seventeenth-century poets, including the Cavalier Lyricists, who acknowledged the second-only-to-Shakespeare Elizabethan playwright Jonson as their master is

A) Martian School.
B) Pre-Raphaelites.
C) Silver-Fork School.
D) Spasmodics.
E) Tribe of Ben.

22. **Not** among the Pulitzer Prize-winning playwright August Wilson's many dramatic works, including his ten-play series The Pittsburg Cycle, is

A) *Fences*.
B) *Joe Turner's Come and Gone*.
C) *Long Day's Journey into Night*.
D) *Ma Rainey's Black Bottom*.
E) *The Piano Lesson*.

23. The twentieth-century American playwright whose dramatic works include *The Glass Menagerie*, *A Streetcar Named Desire*, *Cat on a Hot Tin Roof*, and *The Night of the Iguana* is

A) Edward Albee.
B) David Mamet.
C) Arthur Miller.
D) Eugene O'Neill.
E) Tennessee Williams.

24. The form of repartee developed in classical drama and later employed by many Elizabethan writers, especially those imitating the Senecan tragedies, in which a line-by-line verbal fencing match is exchanged between characters is (the)

A) amoebean verse.
B) flyting.
C) harangue.
D) repetend.
E) stichomythia.

25. The very recently passed German recipient of the 1999 Nobel Prize for Literature, author of *The Tin Drum*, one of his many "frolicsome black fables [that] portray the forgotten face of history," is

A) Heinrich Böll.
B) Rudolf C. Eucken.
C) Günter Grass.
D) Thomas Mann.
E) Theodor Mommsen.

26. In prosody, the system for describing conventional rhythms by dividing lines into feet, indicating the locations of binomial accents, and counting syllables is called

A) annotation.
B) exegesis.
C) intertextual analysis.
D) scansion.
E) typology.

27. Characterized variously as a tragic comedy and a dark comedy, the 1981 Pulitzer Prize-winning drama *Crimes of the Heart* was written by

A) Margaret Edson.
B) Beth Henley.
C) Marsha Norman.
D) Lynn Nottage.
E) Paula Vogel.

28. A student of Marianne Moore, 1949-1950 Poet Laureate, and author of the collection entitled *Poems—North and South*, for which she received the 1956 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry, is

A) Elizabeth Bishop.
B) Rita Dove.
C) Claudia Emerson.
D) Louise Glück.
E) Anne Sexton.

29. Classically, the employment of some unexpected and improbable incident to make things turn out right, and currently, any device whereby an author solves a difficult situation by a forced invention is called

A) *coup de théâtre*.
B) *deus ex machina*.
C) *dolce stil nuovo*.
D) *in medias res*.
E) *scène affàire*.

30. In Greek mythology, the three sister goddesses, Aglaea, Euphrosyne, and Thalia, who confer elegance, beauty, charm, and joy on human beings and nature are the

A) Furies.
B) Graces.
C) Humors.
D) Muses.
E) Worthies.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with Henrik Ibsen's *A Doll House*.
Items 37-42 are associated with Seamus Heaney's translation of *Beowulf*.
Items 43-50 are associated with Emily Dickinson's poetry (selected).

31. In Henrik Ibsen's tragedy *A Doll House*, Kristine Linde's comment, "Not even a sense of loss to feed on," is in response to Nora's question about Mrs. Linde's

A) brothers.
B) children.
C) former husband.
D) friendship with Krogstad.
E) job at the bank.

32. The metaphorical abstraction that Dr. Rank offers in response to Nora's question regarding the guise in which her husband and she should dress for the next masquerade party is

A) Charmed Life.
B) Dancing Macaroons.
C) Enunciated Endearments.
D) Forgery Fantasy.
E) Implicit Misogyny.

33. The referent of Nora's cautious declaration, "my joy and my pride," is

A) her ability to dance the tarantella.
B) her children, Ivar, Bob, and Emmy.
C) her doll house.
D) her relationship with her husband.
E) her underlying reason for owing Krogstad money.

34. While talking to his wife, Torvald Helmer suggests that, contrary to her opinion, the person whose "official career was hardly above reproach" is

A) his own.
B) Nils Krogstad's.
C) Kristine Linde's
D) Nora's father's.
E) Dr. Rank's.

35. Kristine Linde's mistaken guesswork assumption is that Nora borrowed the forty-eight hundred crowns she needed for travel from

A) the bank.
B) a lawyer.
C) Nora's father.
D) the Oslo State Fund.
E) Dr. Rank.

36. The qualified certitude of Helmer's response to both Kristine and Nora's regarding the possibility of his hiring Kristine, "Yes, it's not at all impossible," relies on

A) hyperbole.
B) litotes.
C) paradox.
D) synecdoche.
E) zeugma.

---

37. In Heaney's translation of *Beowulf* the warrior-scop chants, "[T]he Lord was weaving / a victory on His war-loom for the Weather-Geats," which serves as

A) abridgement.
B) *dénouement*.
C) digression.
D) exposition.
E) foreshadowing.

38. The Helming woman who goes "on her rounds, / [. . .] / offering the goblet to all ranks" is

A) Freawaru.
B) Hildeburh.
C) Hygd.
D) Modthryth.
E) Wealhtheow.

39. After the hell-dam's raid in revenge for her loss, Hrothgar laments the loss of his most beloved of friends, his counsellor

A) Aeschere.
B) Breca.
C) Ecgtheow.
D) Hygelac.
E) Wulfgar.

40. The location of the earth-gallery where the battle between the custodian of gold and the ring-giver occurrs is

A) Earnaness.
B) Heorot.
C) Hreasnahill.
D) Hronesness.
E) Ravenswood.

41. The hearth-companion who does not break rank and who is someone in whose "heart / sorrow well[s] up: in a man of worth / the claims of kinship cannot be denied," is

A) Breca.
B) Ecgtheow.
C) Hrothgar.
D) Unferth.
E) Wiglaf.

42. The event that puts Beowulf's mind "in turmoil" so that "unaccustomed anxiety and gloom / confuse his brain" is (the)

A) finding a parking ticket on his wood-wreathed ship.
B) fire-dragon's razing of the coastal region.
C) sharing of several rounds of mead with Hrothgar.
D) snapping of Naegling while fighting the tarn-hag.
E) watching his own mead hall burn to the ground.

Items 43-46 refer to Emily Dickinson's

[I taste a liquor never brewed]

I taste a liquor never brewed,
From tankards scooped in pearl;
Not all the vats upon the Rhine
Yield such an alcohol!

Inebriate of air am I,
And debauchee of dew,
Reeling, through endless summer days,
From inns of molten blue.

When landlords turn the drunken bee
Out of the foxglove's door,
When butterflies renounce their drams,
I shall but drink the more!

Till seraphs swing their snowy hats,
And saints to windows run,
To see the little tippler
Leaning against the sun!

43. The tone of Dickinson's "[I taste]" is delightfully

A) apathetic.
B) capricious.
C) condescending.
D) quarrelsome.
E) sardonic.

44. Line 5's "inebriate" and line 6's "debauchee" contribute to the poem's

A) aesthetic distance.
B) anachronistic imagery.
C) controlling metaphor.
D) objective correlative.
E) transcendent paradox.

45. The source of the persona's intoxication is

A) the dew.
B) her landlord.
C) nature.
D) the tankards.
E) the vats.

46. Dickinson's "tippler" (line 15) is

A) the bee.
B) the butterfly.
C) the foxglove.
D) herself.
E) the liquor.

Items 47-48 refer to Emily Dickinson's

[I bring an unaccustomed wine]

I bring an unaccustomed wine
To lips long parching, next to mine,
And summon them to drink.

Crackling with fever, they essay;
I turn my brimming eyes away,
And come next hour to look.

The hands still hug the tardy glass;
The lips I would have cooled, alas!
Are so superfluous cold,

I would as soon attempt to warm
The bosoms where the frost has lain
Ages beneath the mould.

Some other thirsty there may be
To whom this would have pointed me
Had it remained to speak.

And so I always bear the cup
If, haply, mine may be the drop
Some pilgrim thirst to slake,—

If, haply, any say to me,
"Unto the little, unto me,"
When I at last awake.

47. Line 4 of Dickinson's "[I bring]," "Crackling with fever, they essay," describes

A) an attempt to kiss someone who has a fever.
B) eyes that witness someone dying of thirst.
C) lips attempting to drink.
D) lips talking about being parched.
E) wine causing the lips to dry.

48. The possibility that others, perhaps pilgrims, whose needs might have been pointed out depends on the

A) awakening of the persona.
B) quality of the wine.
C) survival of the dying soul.
D) "tardy glass [. . .] so superfluous[ly] cold."
E) wine being served in a timely manner.

Items 49-50 refer to Emily Dickinson's

[I died for beauty, but was scarce]

I died for beauty, but was scarce
Adjusted in the tomb,
When one who died for truth was lain
In an adjoining room.

He questioned softly why I failed?
"For beauty," I replied.
"And I for truth,—the two are one;
We brethren are," he said.

And so, as kinsmen met a night,
We talked between the rooms,
Until the moss had reached our lips,
And covered up our names.

49. The first stanza of Dickinson's poem suggests

A) acquiescence.
B) apathy.
C) futility.
D) martyrdom.
E) suicide.

50. Ultimately, the persona's recounting of a dialogue with someone who died for truth suggests a(n)

A) acceptance of death.
B) appreciation of beauty.
C) dialogue among kinsmen takes place after death.
D) lost struggle with the moss.
E) uncertainty regarding our finality.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-54 refer to Vachel Lindsay's

The Flower-Fed Buffaloes

The flower-fed buffaloes of the spring
In the days of long ago,
Ranged where the locomotives sing
And the prairie flowers lie low:—
The tossing, blooming, perfumed grass
Is swept away by the wheat,
Wheels and wheels and wheels spin by
In the spring that still is sweet.
But the flower-fed buffaloes of the spring
Left us, long ago.
They gore no more, they bellow no more,
They trundle around the hills no more:—
With the Blackfeet, lying low,
With the Pawnees, lying low,
Lying low.

51. The thematic sense of loss in Lindsay's poem can be understood in terms of the formulaic

A) *carpe diem*.
B) *fin de siècle*.
C) *in medias res.*
D) *jeu d'espirit.*
E) *ubi sunt*.

52. The repeated phrase, "lying low," works as (a)

A) aphorism.
B) euphemism.
C) kenning.
D) neologism.
E) transverse alliteration.

53. Lines 11 through 14 are characterized by

A) antanaclasis.
B) asyndeton.
C) epanalepsis.
D) symploce.
E) tautology.

54. The foundational contrast in Lindsay's "The Flower-Fed Buffaloes" is between

A) Blackfeet and Pawnee.
B) buffaloes and locomotives.
C) hooves and wheels.
D) prairies and wheat fields.
E) singing and bellowing.

Items 55-60 refer to Bartholomew Griffin's

[Fair is my love that feeds among the lilies]

Fair is my love that feeds among the lilies,
The lilies growing in that pleasant garden
Where Cupid's mount, that well belovéd hill is,
And where that little god himself is warden.
See where my love sits in the beds of spices,
Beset all round with camphor, myrrh, and roses,
And interlaced with curious devices,
Which her from all the world apart incloses.
There doth she tune her lute for her delight,
And with sweet music makes the ground to move,
Whilst I, poor I, do sit in heavy plight,
Wailing alone my unrespected love;
Not daring rush into so rare a place,
That gives to her, and she to it, a grace.

55. Griffin's "[Fair is my love that feeds among the lilies]" conforms to the expectations of a(n)

A) Anglo-Italian sonnet.
B) English sonnet.
C) Italian sonnet.
D) Miltonic sonnet.
E) Spenserian sonnet.

56. The first two quatrains of Griffin's sonnet rely on

A) compound rhyme.
B) feminine rhyme.
C) leonine rhyme.
D) masculine rhyme.
E) *rime riche*.

57. Collectively, the strongest imagery in Griffin's sonnet is

A) auditory and tactile.
B) gustatory and tactile.
C) olfactory and auditory.
D) tactile and olfactory.
E) visual and gustatory.

58. Lines 10 and 12 provide an example of

A) dissonance.
B) eye rhyme.
C) identical rhyme.
D) internal rhyme.
E) true rhyme.

59. Lines 1, 3, 5, 11, 12, and 13 begin with a(n)

A) anapestic foot.
B) dactylic foot.
C) iambic foot.
D) spondaic foot.
E) trochaic foot.

60. Line 12's "unrespected love" is best understood as

A) disembodied love.
B) misunderstood love.
C) platonic love.
D) unrequited love.
E) unsolicited love.

Items 61-65 refer to William Wordsworth's

Steamboats, Viaducts, and Railways

Motions and Means, on land and sea at war
With old poetic feeling, not for this,
Shall ye, by Poets even, be judged amiss!
Nor shall your presence, howsoe'er it mar
The loveliness of Nature, prove a bar
To the Mind's gaining that prophetic sense
Of future change, that point of vision, whence
May be discovered what in soul ye are.
In spite of all that beauty may disown
In your harsh features, Nature doth embrace
Her lawful offspring in Man's art; and Time,
Pleased with your triumphs o'er his brother Space,
Accepts from your bold hands the proffered crown
Of hope, and smiles on you with cheer sublime.

61. The speaker in Wordsworth's sonnet is directly addressing examples of

A) natural beauty.
B) personified concepts.
C) poetic feelings.
D) prophetic visions.
E) technology.

62. Wordsworth's sonnet exhibits the pattern of a(n)

A) Anglo-Italian sonnet.
B) English sonnet.
C) Italian sonnet.
D) Miltonic sonnet.
E) Spenserian sonnet.

63. The "judg[ing] amiss [. . .] by Poets even" (line 3) sets up the sonnet's seemingly epiphanic argument that
    A) nature admires steamboats, viaducts, and railways.
    B) points of vision disown harsh features.
    C) proffered crowns bring smiles.
    D) space and time are brothers.
    E) there is no beauty in that which is not natural.

64. Line 4's *howsoe'er* and line 12's *o'er* are examples of
    A) apostrophe.
    B) ellipsis.
    C) metathesis.
    D) pleonasm.
    E) syncope.

65. The "lawful offspring" assessment found in the eleventh line of Wordsworth's poem finds support in the reasoning that "the Mind" (line 6) is
    A) also of nature.
    B) capable of judging.
    C) capable of prophecy.
    D) discovered in the soul.
    E) possessed of a poetic sense of things.

Required tie-breaking essay prompt immediately below.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Sharon Olds's "He Comes for the Jewish Family, 1942," and offer a discussion of the emotional crescendo that underscores the theme and tone of the poem.

He Comes for the Jewish Family, 1942

When the German came, they knew he would take them.
They knew his body hated them,
they could feel it in their bodies when he looked at them,
a kind of wax spread over their skin.
They didn't hate anything like that,
not even the pig, who was merely unclean,
so they knew he was capable of anything.
They had heard about trucks, they could smell his passion
to put them in trucks, he would do it to the children
as avidly as to them. He came and they
looked at their daughter standing with her music
in her hand, the page covered with dots and
lines like some dark language, and they knew
he would take her, their bodies even knew about the camps,
they could smell his gold hair smoking,
they knew it was the end. What they did not know was the
way he would pick her cello up
by the scroll neck and take its dark
lovely body shape and break it
against the fireplace. The brickwork crushed the
amber satiny wood, they stood and
stared at him in terror.

Sharon Olds

ANSWER SHEET

UIL Literary Criticism

Items 1-30 **1** *point each*

1. ____
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Items 31-65 **2** *points each*

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Part 3

contestant number

SCORE

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties.

Simply adjust ranking.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

FIRST GRADER

number correct x 1 _____

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number correct x 2 _____

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initials

SECOND GRADER

number correct x 1 _____

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THIRD GRADER

number correct x 1 _____

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KEY

UIL Literary Criticism
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line arrows up ➔

1.	D	425
2.	B	185
3.	C	602
4.	E	447
5.	A	7
6.	D	542
7.	A	146
8.	E	486
9.	D	418
10.	A	10
11.	C	432
12.	D	176
13.	A	3
14.	D	362
15.	A	234
16.	E	396
17.	A	115
18.	C	
19.	B	173, 435
20.	C	272
21.	E	485
22.	C	607
23.	E	581
24.	E	455
25.	C	601
26.	D	430
27.	B	608
28.	A	604
29.	B	137
30.	B	221
31.	C	49
32.	A	102
33.	E	64
34.	D	78
35.	E	75
36.	B	60, 275
37.	E	696-97
38.	E	620-22
39.	A	1323
40.	A	3032
41.	E	2599
42.	B	2331-34
43.	B	
44.	C	108
45.	C	
46.	D	
47.	C	
48.	C	
49.	D	
50.	A	
51.	E	489
52.	B	186
53.	D	468
54.	B	
55.	B	173
56.	B	196
57.	C	
58.	B	191
59.	D	452
60.	D	
61.	E	
62.	C	260
63.	A	
64.	E	469
65.	A	

FOLD along the **three** longitudinal lines for ease in grading. ➔

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties. ***Simply adjust ranking***.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

DO NOT mark (cross out) actual **LETTER** answer; mark the answer **NUMERAL**.

Page numbers refer to the *Handbook* 12e, to the Signet *House*, to the Norton *Beowulf*, and to Collins's Dickinson collection.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Sharon Olds's "He Comes for the Jewish Family, 1942"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the emotional crescendo that underscores the theme and the tone of Olds's "He Comes for the Jewish Family, 1942" include

aesthetics,
aesthetic distance,
diction,
free verse,
imagery,
irony,
objective correlative,
simile,
synecdoche,
theme, and
tone.

Sharon Olds's poem is a fairly straightforward portrayal of the benighted barbarity that often finds occasion and opportunity in uniformed authority. The student might recognize, additionally, something of the distance that is established in the poem's lack of emotively charged diction. The writer might perceive a level of irony in this disconnect.

The contestant has been asked to develop a discussion of the crescendo that begins as a chronologically placed knowledge-in-anticipation and ends with the silence that follows the inferred loudness of the brickwork's crushing of the daughter's cello (lines 20-21), the brickwork having been given the role of active destroyer. The idea that a fellow human being, even one intent on a personal role in a genocide, could play the active role in the destruction of that which is party to beauty, the cello, is presented as unfathomable through the aesthetic distance defining the speaker's own role. Thus an awareness of the narrative quality of the poem's setting up the final lines' "they stood and / stared at him in terror" might inform the essay response.

The triad that is the victimizer, the victims, and the instrument representing, quintessentially the terminal—both primitive and sophisticated—completeness of human expression, the shared-across-cultures love of music, is lined up as target, the cello in unexpected inclusion. The anticipated dehumanization, torture, rape, and murder is trumped, in the eyes of the speaker and of the victims who are about to be taken to their deaths, by the unanticipated destruction of, in the concrete, the beauty of music, arguably so much a part of both Jewish and German traditions. The perceptive student might sense in the German's action an envy of the artistry and beauty that is frequently synonymous with Jewish musical accomplishment. The well-read contestant might reference Hannah Arendt's "banality of evil."